‘We pay you taxes and you protect our lives and property’ was the cornerstone on which the concept of a nation-state had evolved. Here was a prime minister of a twentieth-century ‘democratic, socialist and secular’ Republic of India, who had all the resources at his disposal to fulfil this basic constitutional obligation towards thousands of law abiding, innocent Sikh citizens of the country, but he chose not to. If the newly installed prime minster wanted to avert that tragedy, he just had to call Home Minister P.V. Narasimha Rao (later prime minister) on the phone directly or tell his experienced principal secretary to convey his message to him. But he didn’t, or chose not to, for the reasons mentioned below.

A new prime minister

Things were going as planned till Indira Gandhi’s assassination. If allowed to go unavenged, this tragic loss had the potential of derailing the Congress party’s election campaign and jeopardizing Rajiv Gandhi’s succession as prime minister of the country. Director (R) Gary Saxena had already warned me on 8 June 1984 (mentioned earlier in this chapter) of the possibility of large-scale killings of Sikhs in Delhi in case Indira Gandhi was assassinated by a Sikh for her perceived role in the developments in Punjab leading to Operation Blue Star. It would thus appear that the 1 Akbar Road group had visualized such a possibility in the aftermath of Operation Blue Star and had planned for it, when and if the time came for its implementation.

Let us examine what members of the 1 Akbar Road group were doing on the day Indira Gandhi was shot, and how by that evening the riots had turned into an anti-Sikh pogrom. Rajiv Gandhi learnt about his mother being shot from Finance Minister Pranab Mukherjee while addressing an election rally at Contai (Kolaghat) in West Bengal. Cutting his speech short, both Rajiv and Mukherjee reached Kolaghat by road around noon, left for Calcutta by helicopter and took a special Indian Airlines flight to New Delhi at around 1 p.m., reaching New Delhi at 3 p.m. Incidentally, anti-Sikh riots started in some pockets of Kolkata soon after Rajiv’s plane left Kolkata airport. In a West Bengal ruled by the CPI(M) with Jyoti